In short, the Kanikkar of the Agastya Malai were typical hunter-gatherers, living close to nature and very much on the edge. Like their ancestors before them, these tribes took only what they needed from their forest surrounds, and when the rains came on they retreated to rock-shelters, where their previously unconsidered wall paintings and petroglyphs are now being rediscovered all over the Indian hinterland. Their descendants remain a marginalised underclass still shamefully looked down upon by India's urbanites. All the same, they and others like them constitute India's most senior citizens.

So now to the question of origins. Where did hunter-gatherers akin to the Kanikkar come from? The first thing to be said is that much of what you and I learned at school or college is already out of date, irrespective of when you left school, so fast are such new sciences as archaeogenetics developing alongside new theories such as that of the 'Aquatic Ape'. That theory, first put forward by the marine biologist Sir Alister Hardy in 1960, argues that early humans did not learn to stand upright as hunters on the wide open spaces of the African savannah, as stated in virtually every biology textbook written in the twentieth century, but by living alongside water and coastal strips, and by foraging for food such as mussels and shellfish in the shallows – a process that led to their bodies adapting to make the best of their watery environment.[12]

Archaeogenetics is still in its infancy yet already advanced enough to tell us that those of us without recent African ancestry are descendants of a handful of fertile women who were part of a prehistoric eastward migration out of East Africa. These women carried in their mitochondrial DNA (mtDNA) the Haplogroup L (a haplogroup being a population group sharing a common ancestor through either the matrilineal or patrilineal line). For reasons unknown, these Haplogroup L-bearers crossed into the Arabian peninsula,